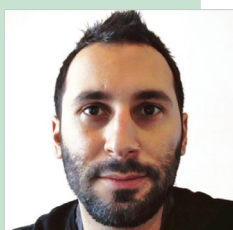


Why And How To Become AN OPEN SOURCE CONTRIBUTOR

Open source is often associated with coding, giving the impression it's meant only for computer geeks. But anybody can become an open source contributor—even if they haven't written a line of code their entire life. Sounds interesting? Read on



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The beginning of the new year calls you to bring about a change in yourself. It could be learning a new skill, becoming healthy, performing your best at work or studies, or anything fruitful that will improve you. In the process, you also want that change to benefit others. Here is an interesting proposition to help you become an open source contributor.

But why?

Why not? After all, it is exciting and will help you achieve your objectives. And, most importantly, you do not need to be an expert in coding. You can contribute without possessing any prior coding experience.

Interested? Let's do it. But first a bit of basic background. The formal definition of open source software goes like this:

Open source software is a software

whose source code is released under a license that grants anyone the right to inspect, modify, and distribute it for any purpose. The two important things to note in this definition are 'source code' and 'license.'

Releasing a source code for free does not hinder you from selling the result of your creation. It is possible to earn money based on open source software and make a living out of it. Companies including GitHub and MongoDB, to name a few, are doing just that. Nevertheless, there is a lot more to simply giving away all your software for free.

There is also a difference between free software and open source software. While free software is part of the larger open source community, the opposite is untrue. Open source software allows everyone the right to inspect, modify, and distribute its code. However, free software also forces you to redistribute any changes you made to it under the original license.

Popular open source licenses

There are essentially two different categories. First, there are permissive licenses that allow modifications to the original software code and sell the modified version. Open source codes can be combined and released with little to no constraints, as long as the original licenses and copyrights are not altered. Some common examples of this license category are the MIT license (MIT), Apache license 2.0 (Apache 2.0), and 3-clause BSD license (BSD-3-Clause).

Second, there are copyleft licenses.

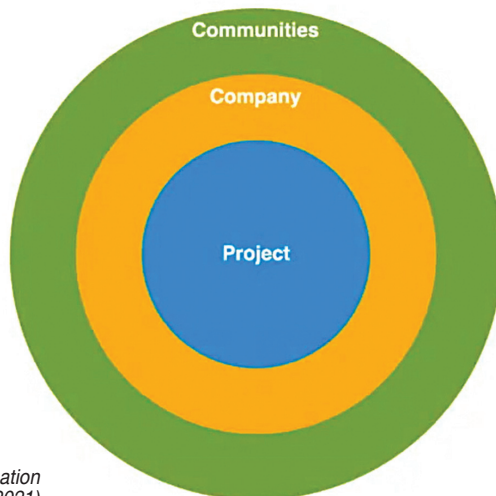


Fig. 1: Circles of communication
(Credit: OSI 2021)